Radiant Vermin

By Phillip Ridley

Suggested Roles: *ACTRESS: Jill and Miss Dee*
ACTOR: Ollie

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Enter Ollie and Jill, Jill is holding a baby.

JILL: **(Pg 7-8)** Hello, I'm Jill

OLLIE: And I'm Ollie.

JILL: This is our son Benjy.

OLLIE: We'd like to tell you about our home.

JILL: Our ***dream*** home [and] how we got it.

OLLIE: Exactly. Because . . . well . . .

JILL: We're good people. We ***try*** to be.

OLLIE: And yet . . . some of the things we've done – well . . . they're not exactly . . . nice. In fact, they're . . . horrible.

JILL: I'm afraid they are, yes.

OLLIE: But I'm sure once we've explained

JILL: ***Why*** we did --

OLLIE: ***What*** we did –

JILL: Then you'll understand.

INTRODUCTION

TOGETHER: *Radiant Vermin by Phillip Ridley*

******6 months before Benjy is born******

JILL: **(Pg 9)** We've just got a letter. Hand delivered. Looks official. *(reading)* 'Dear Mr. and Mrs. Swift . . . My name is Miss Dee and I have been asked to head a new department of the government's housing program known as the Department of Social Regeneration through the Creation of Dream Homes. You've been selected

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for participation in our new scheme. To put it simply. We will give you a house.'

OLLIE: ***What?!*** *(Takes letter and continues reading)* 'To hear more, meet me at the house in question tomorrow at midday. The address is below along with directions.' *(Scene shift)* **(Pg 10)** It's the next day. *(The Swifts arrive at the house and exit their car)*

JILL: **(Pg 11-12)** The front of the house looks okay. *(peering through the windows; Ollie is more hesitant)* Big rooms. *(She tries the door)* The front door's open! Miss Dee?! . . . Miss Dee?!

OLLIE: You're not going inside?!

JILL: Why not? *(beat)* Ollie! *(he joins her)* The hallway's lovely.

OLLIE: If you like the smell of damp.

JILL: Two reception rooms. We can knock that wall down. More open-plan.

OLLIE: Am I the only one who can see loose wires everywhere? *(Jill wanders into another room)*

JILL: The kitchen's huge! . . . [and] Three bedrooms. Three! This would make the ***perfect*** nursery, wouldn't it? *(Miss Dee has appeared in true fairy godmother style)*

MISS DEE: Miss Dee – that's me! What a joy to meet you at last!

OLLIE: **(Pg 13-15)** Have we been under surveillance?

MISS DEE: What on earth makes you say that?

JILL: Miss Dee . . . this house –

MISS DEE: The contract's in my bag! *(Gives contract to Ollie)*

OLLIE: I have some questions first. *(as he looks over the contract)* So . . we just get ***given*** it. This house. And it's ours. You can't take it back? Not ever?

MISS DEE: Clause One, as you see.

OLLIE: And if we sell it?

MISS DEE: Clause Two.

OLLIE: . . . We keep all the money.

JILL: Oh, Ollie, it's too good to be true.

OLLIE: Dad used to say if something's too good to be true it usually is. *(Thunder crash or*

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other sound effect)

MISS DEE: Children please. Listen to Miss Dee. This house is a wonderful chance for you both. I tell you – as God is my witness- no two people are more deserving.

OLLIE: We're nothing special.

MISS DEE: Nothing special? Jillian! When your mums arthritis got so bad her hand swelled up like rubber gloves full of golf balls – who was it washed her? Dressed her, fed her and – forgive any inappropriate language – took her to the toilet?

JILL: Any daughter would have done the same.

MISS DEE: And you, Oliver! Living with your dad's alcoholism wasn't easy. All hugs and kissed one second then [one] too many and – BAHM!

OLLIE: Dad was ***never*** violent.

MISS DEE: Not physically. But verbally? Yet you never retaliated. Not once. You're ***both*** good people.

JILL: (Pg 20) Give me that contract! *(Snatches the contract and signs)* I want this house! *(to Ollie)* Red Ocean Estate sucks all the joy out of you. I don't want to bring our baby into a world like that. What will its future be? Drugs? Gangs? Prison? I want ***more*** than that for our child. I want . . . this house. I know there'll be problems. But at least we'll have the ***hope*** of things getting better. *(Ollie signs contract)*

*******The Next Night – In Their New Home*******

OLLIE: (Pg 21-22) *(Stretching)* Bedtime? **JILL:** We haven't put a curtain up!

OLLIE: There's no neighbors, Jill. *(a look from Jill)* Okay, okay. I'll hang a sheet over it. *(he peers outside as he is hanging the sheet)* Hang on! What's that? *(Jill goes to see)*

JILL: Oh! A bonfire. **OLLIE:** There's another one.

JILL: Who's made them, d'you think?

OLLIE: The homeless. Didn't you see them under the flyover? Cardboard City.

JILL: If we can see their fire, I'm sure they can see our candles.

OLLIE: (Pg 23-26) . . . . Next night! *(rustling sounds)*

JILL: . . . What's that? A noise . . . Downstairs. Shhhh!

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OLLIE: It's coming from the kitchen.

JILL: *(Panicked)* It's one of the homeless. They saw our candles. I told you they would!

(Ollie creeps to the bedroom door) What're you doing? You're not going downstairs!? There might be more than one down there, Ollie.

OLLIE: Then I'll . . . politely ask them to leave.

JILL: Politely ask them?!

OLLIE: They're just homeless, Jill. Not psycho killers.

JILL: What're you looking for? **OLLIE:** A weapon.

JILL: I thought you just said –

OLLIE: Candlestick! This'll crack a skull in! *(he exits the bedroom and heads to the kitchen)*

(From off stage) AHHH! Someone's grabbed me from behind! *(Sounds of a struggle)*

JILL: *(When it is quiet, Jill races downstairs)* Ollie! *(Ollie keeps her from entering the kitchen)*

OLLIE: We . . . we struggled . . . he stumbled and he fell.

JILL: He's . . . he's dead?!

OLLIE: Listen to me, Jill. Deep breaths *(Jill breathes deep)* Sit on the stiars . . . now what's happened here is just a bit of bad luck.

JILL: Look! Under the kitchen door. **OLLIE:** Light?

JILL: There's no electric, Ollie. So what's causing the -- I want to know what it is, Ollie! I want to know right now. It's fading . . . it's gone.

OLLIE: Wait here. . . *(pushes open the kitchen door a crack and stares – in shock)* The body. . . It's gone. *(Jill joins Ollie and screams . . . in delight)*

JILL: It's the kitchen we saw in Selfridges!

OLLIE: *(Ollie's phone chimes)* Text. Unknown sender. *(reads text)* 'Enjoy your dream home. Love, Miss Dee.'

******* 7 hours later*******

JILL: (Pg 30) . . . What're you saying, Ollie? You killed a vagrant and he's been reincarnated as a designer kitchen?!

OLLIE: Isn't that quite clearly what ***has*** happened? *(he exits)*

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JILL: **(Pg 31-33)** I can't stay here. I won't! *(to audience)* A man died here last night. Oh, I know what some of you are thinking. He was just a vagrant. When I see a homeless person I always give some money. I know what you're thinking: "They'll just spend it on drugs." Well, some might, yes. But most just want a sandwich. Another thing, when you walk past one of them on the street and you **don't** give any money, they mumble something like 'Have a nice day." Like they're trying to make us feel guilty. Guilty for what? Having self-respect? Aspiring to a better life. Why should I – why should any of us? – feel guilty about that? I'm going to the kitchen! *(As she enters a beautiful sound effect)* Oh! Notice the way the marble shines? Beautiful hot water! And the cupboards full of food. The fridge is full too! *(Ollie enters and goes to the sink to wash his hands)* Oh, don't wash your hands in the kitchen sink, Ollie!

OLLIE: No hot water upstairs.

JILL: *(thinking)* Perhaps we can get – not just hot water – but a whole new bathroom. A bathroom every bit as good as this new kitchen.

OLLIE: What happened last night was an accident. What you're asking me to do now – this is pre-meditated, cold-blooded . . .

JILL: I want a bath!

OLLIE: And you're prepared to murder for it?! What if it doesn't work?

JILL: I think we should at least . . . try.

******* The Renovations Continue******

OLLIE: **(Pg 35-36)** Stab!

JILL: The dead Intruder With the Baseball Cap is starting to sparkle with fairy lights. It's the staircase and hallway I saw in Ideal Home magazine!

OLLIE: Stab! The Intruder With the Limp is starting to sparkle with . . .

JILL: Fairylights! Outside! – It's the front garden I saw in Perfect Gardens and Porches magazine. Look, Ollie, look!

OLLIE: It's the new Lamborghini Huracan LP 610-2 Super Trofeo!

JILL: Let's go for a spin.

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OLLIE: Who! Jill. What're you thinking? I kill two people -- Brutally. And then a new car comes along and Shazam! You think I can just forget all about it?! Just like that?

JILL and OLLIE: YESSSSS!

*******The New Plan*******

OLLIE: **(Pg 38-39)** If we're going to carry on . . .

JILL: The renovations? Oh, I think we should!

OLLIE: So do i. But, we can't have any more . . . messiness. Not for ***my*** sake, you understand.

JILL: Of course not. For their sake. The renovations have to be humane. And, Ollie? I can't see any of it. It'll upset baby. And I don't want to know . . . anything about them. Don't ever tell me their names. And we can't wait for them to break in. You'll have to get in the car and . . .

OLLIE: Find them.

JILL: The ones you choose . . . they should only be the ones who . . . deserve it.

OLLIE: Deserve it?

JILL: The one who will never . . . contribute.

OLLIE: Of course . . . the scum.

JILL: The scroungers.

OLLIE: The spongers.

JILL: The vermin – Aw! *(she rubs her stomach lovingly)*

OLLIE: *(Ollie touches Jill's belly and chuckles)* He's saying 'Let me out of here!'

JILL: Not yet! We've got your dream home to get ready first. *(Beat)*

OLLIE: *(to audience)* Next day. I've been trying to solve the problem of humane home renovation. After many hours of trial and error, I've finally come up with something I think ticks all the boxes. Electrocution! Yessss! Fast. Silent. Clean And so - Ta dah! This is the answer to our prayers. Think cattle prod times a million.

JILL: **(Pg 40-42)** I have married a genius! BZZZZZ! It's the bathroom I saw in Best Bathroom magazine!

OLLIE: After that the renovations – oh, they happened quickly. Garage, Our bedroom.

JILL: Back Garden, Utility room

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OLLIE: Spare bedroom, Loft, Nursery

JILL: It all looked wonderful. *(a sound attracts her attention)* Oh! What's that?

OLLIE: **(Pg 80-83)** Sounds like the letterbox. . . . *(he retrieves a letter from the box by the front door)* Hand delivered. . . From Larry *(reading)* Dear Ollie and Jill, I speak on behalf of all your good neighbors. It has come to our attention that some of your behavior is not beneficial to the tone of the neighborhood.

JILL: Not beneficial to the?! *(Snatches letter from Ollie)* Namely, your persistence in bringing vagrants back to your house. May I remind you, these vagrants are not only potential robbers, but also carriers of disease.

OLLIE: The heartless bastard!

JILL: To conclude, you are lowering the value of our houses.

OLLIE: What!??

JILL: We are instigating a Neighborhood Watch. We are setting up CCTV cameras and we would be grateful if you would sign the enclosed contract . . .

OLLIE: We can't do any more renovations, can we?

JILL: They'll be watching us all the time.

MISS DEE: *(Appears)* Hello, children. I know – That silly letter. Something like this always happens. Clause Six. *(makes a tsking sound and shakes her head)*

JILL: Maintain discretion.

MISS DEE: We have reached . . . "the moment" where you have to make a decision. To say or . . . move on. *(beat)* I have a new contract for you here. Exactly the same.

OLLIE: With the same . . . perks?

MISS DEE: Perks? I've no idea what you mean. If you can make the new house look as wonderful as this, you'll make Miss Dee very proud. [but] a friendly warning . . . with each new house, it sometimes feels the sacrifices we have to make . . . double.

OLLIE: *(draws Jill aside)* You know what she's saying?

JILL: Each renovation will need two renovators.

OLLIE: That's a lot of renovators, Jill.

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JILL: We can't stay here and never renovate again. That's just not an option you know that! Miss Dee!

TOGETHER: We'll sign!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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